

HAVING MANN AS ITS CM CANDIDATE SHOULD REASSURE SIKH VOTERS THAT AAP WILL NOT BE HINDU-DOMINATED

the hustings. But if Channi does lead the Congress to victory, he will become a national figure—perhaps only the second Dalit from Punjab to attain that after Kanshi Ram.

Mann: The Maverick

For a satirist, it's an ironic fate that has befallen Mann: to be the butt of jokes made by his political opponents. Hitting two of his betes noires with one stone, Amarinder describes Mann as another Sidhu—"except he doesn't sit and laugh in his chair but does stand-up jokes". Channi says Mann is unfit for the job because there's a vast difference between running a state and being on stage. It's a mark of Punjab's multi-polar battle that he too resorts to double-edged humour, taking a swipe at his former boss while going for Mann! He says, "Captain Saab closes shop at 4 pm and the party begins at home. Mann does that from 6 pm onwards—only a two-hour difference." Sukhbir is more direct, "He is a binge drinker and I dread the day people like him are made to the lead the state."

The 48-year-old Mann remains unfazed by the avalanche of taunts. "I am a satirist and social critic, not a comedian," he begins his retort. "It was Captain Saab who made a joke of the people's verdict. For four and a half years, he didn't open the doors of his palace to them." He brushes aside Sukhbir's remarks saying, "People don't trust him anymore. He doesn't go to Parliament, though he is an MP. And they have been trying to fix me with such remarks for the past seven years." As for Channi, he chooses to try and dismantle his core strength. "He calls himself an *aam aadmi* (common man) but has declared property of over Rs 110 crore. He is a *nakli* (fake) *aam aadmi*," says Mann. Like Channi, Mann too wept openly when he was anointed chief ministerial candidate by AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal.

That decision was taken to stymie Opposition criticism on a sensitive point that had harmed AAP even last time: the idea that Kejriwal was positioning himself to become CM of Punjab if AAP wins. Having Mann as the CM face would reassure Sikh voters that the party was not going to be a Hindu-dominated one. But it hasn't stopped the barbs insinuating that Mann would be just a rubber stamp for Kejriwal, who plans to run the state remotely. The talk gained traction when, initially, the party distributed campaign flags displaying its broom symbol and Kejriwal's face, adorned with the slogan *Ek Mauka Kejriwal Nu* (One chance for Kejriwal). Mann counters the charge of him being just a puppet, saying, "Captain went to Delhi as CM to meet Sonia Gandhi and she refused to see him. Punjab has to bear that shame. Look at Channi...he is called to Delhi so frequently. In contrast, in the past four months, I went to Delhi maybe once. It is Kejriwal who comes to Punjab."